

error messages when using the drive. What is the problem?

▲ The problem does not lie in the drive. Actually, this is a problem faced by many DVD drive users. Your first move should be to check whether you have the right and/or the latest drivers. Driver problems are the major cause of all playback-related issues—freezing screens while playing DVDs, poor sound, error messages, and so on. You will usually find the latest drivers on the Web site of the manufacturer of your drive. At the same time, also make sure that you have the right drivers for your graphics adapter and DVD decoder.

Next, you should check if the DMA or Sync Data Transfer box is checked in Windows. Go to **Start > Settings > Control Panel > System > Device Manager**. Here, choose CD-ROM, click on Driver Properties, and choose the Settings tab. Make sure the appropriate box is checked, depending on whether it's an IDE drive or a SCSI drive. If you face any problem (which generally happens when you use an AMD processor or a VIA chipset) uncheck the DMA option and restart.

Finally, you could try a few basic tips while playing DVDs that are known to help:

Close any unwanted programs that are running in the background. Allocate more memory to the DVD player, if there is an option for the same. SCSI DVD-ROM drives should either be the first or last

device in the SCSI chain with appropriate terminations.

If you are viewing the DVD on a TV, the problems could also be due to a long cable or poor contrast settings.

Cannot play copy-protected files

Q I recently copied a movie file from a DVD to my hard disk drive. Now I have the essential software to play it, but when I tried to play it, I got an error message saying, "Cannot play copy-protected files." What's wrong?

A DVDs store DVD video as a .VOB file, which is essentially a specialised MPEG-2 file. Most MPEG-2 decoders and players can play them. However, all movies on a DVD are encrypted with CSS copy protection. This is an encryption technique, with the corresponding decryption keys being stored in the normally

// Eliminate buffer underruns by experimenting with lower burn-speed settings //

inaccessible lead-in area of the disc. If you copy the contents of an encrypted DVD to a hard drive, these keys are not, or rather, cannot be copied. So when you try to play the VOB file, the software decoder tries to request the keys from the DVD-ROM drive, which fails, and then shows the error message.

Buffer under-run error when burning CDs

Q When I try to write to my CD-R using my CD-Writer, I get a buffer under-run error. Please tell me what this means and how it can be solved.

A A CD-RW requires an uninterrupted data stream from the hard drive to write successfully to a CD. A buffer under-run message appears when the data stream is interrupted. This may also occur if another program interrupts the writing process or if your writer's write speed is set too high. To solve the problem, there are a few things you could try out:

Try recording at a lower speed. Make sure that no other program is running which could possibly interfere with your CD-writing process. Examples of such programs are usually fax and e-mail programs, screensavers, etc. Close or disable

any such programs. Also turn off the power saving features of the PC. You can also indulge in some tweaking up and basic maintenance of your PC. This should include regular scanning and defragmenting of the hard disk, as well as cleaning files and folders in the Windows temp folder that you do not require often. These simple tips usually do the trick and fix the problem.

Before you Open your Cabinet

Make sure you do all this before baring your computer:

■ Unplug all power sources and remove all power cables from the mains and from your SMPS.

■ Unplug all peripherals from the computer and make sure no remaining cable is left hanging from the PC.

■ To safeguard against damage from static electricity touch your hand to another metal surface (non-

powder coated surface of the computer cabinet will also suffice).

■ Check your computer's manual, for the proper way to remove your case. If you don't have a manual, look at the back of the computer. You should see about

four-six screws holding the case to the frame.

Simply remove the screws. The cover should slide off the computer easily with little effort.



Recording more than the stated disc capacity

Q Most CD-Rs allow a recording time of some 74 minutes. I have been told that it is possible to record more than this time. Is it true? If yes, how can I record more than the stated disc capacity?

A CD-Rs allow enough space to hold at least 74 minutes of CD-DA audio CD format. The format defines the number of tracks on the disc which contain digital audio data and error correction routines that save sound from minor data loss. The format allows for a total of 74 minutes of digital sound to be transferred at a rate of 150 kilobytes per second (KBps) and 90 seconds of digital silence. The silent area, called the 'lead-out', is included so that a CD player